

tener, this means that you will hear a very undesirable distortion and crackling from your speakers, not to mention risking permanent damage to them.

To see what this looks like in a waveform editor, pick any audio clip and give it an ampli-

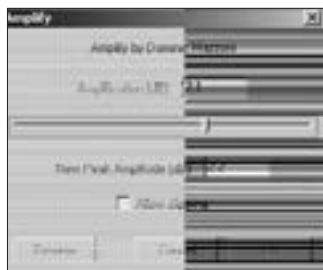


Audition warns you a little later

fication of 10 dB or more. Now, in your waveform editor, zoom into the top of the wave and scroll through the wave. You will see at many places where the wave “flattens out” at the peak and stays that way for a while before coming back down. This is called Clipping—the waveform is “clipped” at the maximum capacity of your soundcard’s amplifier.

Every audio editing tool will have at least one way to warn you before you end up with a clipped waveform. Audacity won’t even let you apply amplification if it sees that the audio is going to be clipped (unless, of course, you explicitly tell it to allow clipping. A checkbox called Allow Clipping will let you amplify such that the loudest sound will be over the allowed threshold—which means it will probably distort at that point.). Audition, on the other hand, will show you red warning signs in the Levels frame at the bottom.

Of course, adjusting amplification is something you’ll need to control yourself, so it’s going to be quite inconvenient when you have a hundred or so audio files (and don’t we all!) that need tweaking. For amplification that’s a no-brainer and can safely be run in a batch, you need to normalise the audio.



You shall not clip! Audacity stops you from mistakes you might regret